

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

DOW JONES | News Corp

WEDNESDAY, JANUARY 7, 2026 ~ VOL. CCLXXXVII NO. 5

WSJ.com

★★★★ \$5.00

DJIA 49462.08 ▲ 484.90 0.99%

NASDAQ 23547.17 ▲ 0.6%

STOXX 600 605.28 ▲ 0.6%

10-YR. TREAS. ▼ 4/32, yield 4.178%

OIL \$57.13 ▼ \$1.19

GOLD \$4,482.20 ▲ \$45.30

EURO \$1.1689

YEN 156.68

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Peter Zaffino** will step down as chief executive of American International Group after a turbulent period that peaked with the insurer insisting that it wasn't for sale. **B1**

◆ **The Dow and S&P 500** rose to records, gaining 0.6% and 1%, respectively, while the Nasdaq advanced 0.6%. **B1**

◆ **Hilton took the** relatively rare step of removing a hotel from its system amid online criticism over the property's refusal to house ICE officers destined for Minneapolis. **B1**

◆ **Eli Lilly is in** advanced talks to acquire Ventyx Biosciences for more than \$1 billion, targeting a company that has been developing inflammation inhibitors. **B3**

◆ **An equipment-financing** company lent money to First Brands at usurious rates as part of a kickback scheme with a top executive, according to the auto-parts supplier's creditors. **B2**

◆ **Ford's fourth-quarter** sales rose from the prior year, as lower-priced truck sales helped it more than offset a decline in electric vehicles. **B2**

◆ **Brewer AB InBev** agreed to repurchase a minority stake in its U.S.-based metal-container plants for around \$3 billion to strengthen its security of supply. **B3**

◆ **Morgan Stanley plans** to launch exchange-traded funds holding bitcoin and solana, joining traditional bank peers in embracing crypto. **B3**

◆ **Meta Platforms said** it would delay rolling out its latest smartglasses model to foreign countries, deferring to high demand from customers in the U.S. **B4**

Worldwide

◆ **Venezuela's new leader** is treading a fine line as she tries to withstand U.S. pressure while keeping the country's revolutionary government from dissolving into interne-cine struggle. **A1, A5, A6**
◆ **Trump said** Venezuela will give the U.S. up to 50 million barrels of sanctioned oil, with proceeds overseen by the White House. **A5**

◆ **Trump's renewed designs** on Greenland are causing growing alarm among Western allies, with Denmark warning that any U.S. seizure of the island would spell the end of NATO. **A1, A6**

◆ **The suspect in last** month's mass shooting at Brown University and subsequent killing of an MIT professor admitted to the attacks in a series of short videos. **A3**

◆ **The White House** used a webpage to recast the Jan. 6, 2021, attack on the Capitol as a "peaceful protest" that was deliberately mischaracterized by Democrats. **A3**

◆ **The U.K. and France** will set up military hubs across Ukraine and build facilities to produce weapons and equipment for Kyiv if a cease-fire is reached, the U.K.'s Starmer said. **A5**

◆ **Nineteen states raised** their minimum wage starting this month, providing a pay bump to an estimated 8.3 million workers. **A2**

◆ **Died: Aldrich Ames**, 84, CIA turncoat who sold secrets to Moscow. **A2** ...
◆ **Michael Reagan**, 80, son of President Reagan and a conservative commentator. **A2** ...
◆ **Doug LaMalfa**, 65, GOP congressman of California. **A4**

CONTENTS		Opinion.....	A13-15
Arts in Review.....	A11	Personal Journal A9-10	
Business & Finance B2-3		Property Report.....	B6
Business News.....	B11	Sports.....	A16
Crossword.....	A10	Technology.....	B4
Heard on Street.....	B11	U.S. News.....	A2-4
Markets.....	B10	World News.....	A5-7



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KEVIN LAMARQUE/REUTERS

President Trump, addressing GOP lawmakers Tuesday, is openly pursuing a takeover of Greenland after intervening in Venezuela.

President's Greenland Demand Spreads Alarm Among Allies

European leaders, reluctant to criticize U.S. over Venezuela, fear end of NATO

President Trump's embrace of military interventionism in Latin America has led to the diplomatic equivalent of em-

By **Marcus Walker**
in Rome and
Matthew Dalton
in Paris

barrassed coughing from the U.S.'s allies in Europe. But his renewed designs on the Danish territory of Greenland are

causing growing alarm.

Since the U.S. military raid on Caracas that captured Venezuelan strongman Nicolás Maduro, Trump has threatened to use force elsewhere in the Western Hemisphere and redoubled his demand for a U.S. takeover of Greenland.

Denmark has urged the U.S. to stop threatening the territory of a historic ally and warned that any U.S. military operation to seize Greenland would spell the end of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization. Major European NATO members rallied to Denmark's side, calling on the U.S. to choose cooperation, not coercion, in a statement Tuesday.

The past few days have renewed fears in Europe that the Western alliance is fracturing. Trump's growing taste for big-stick diplomacy in the Americas is adding to fears among traditional allies that the U.S. is actively dismantling the post-World War II international order, based on principles such as protecting the sovereignty of states and limiting the use of military force.

In its place, allies fear, is a division of the world into great-power spheres of influence, with the U.S., China and Russia becoming regional hegemons while curtailing the sovereignty of smaller countries. Faced with that, European

governments' instinct has been to try to salvage what is left of the West, including by taking an emollient line on U.S. intervention in Venezuela to avoid angering Trump. In European capitals, the message has been good riddance to Maduro—but that Trump's way of removing him maybe wasn't ideal.

President Emmanuel Macron of France initially said Venezuelans could rejoice at Maduro's fall. A spokeswoman later said the president didn't support

Please turn to page A6

◆ **Rubio tells lawmakers aim** is to buy Greenland..... **A6**
◆ **U.K., France plan military** hubs in Ukraine..... **A5**

L.A. Fire Recovery, A Year on, Is Rocky

Many homeowners are still waiting for insurance payouts, building permits

MALIBU, Calif.—High above the crashing Pacific, Roxanne White walks the burned grounds of what used to be her family's home. She stops next to a patch of bare dirt

By **Jim Carlton**,
Shane Shifflett and
Rebecca Picciotto

where once a long kitchen table had hosted countless Thanksgiving dinners.

"I feel we'll never do that again," White, 69, said, choking up as she stared at the remnants of a house lost in the Los Angeles fires last year that her parents built half a

century ago. "I mean, not here."

White is among the majority of victims still struggling to rebuild after wind-driven fires last January tore through Southern California, killing at least 31 and destroying more than 10,000 single-family homes. The \$65 billion in losses are the largest for a wildfire disaster in U.S. history, according to an estimate by reinsurance broker Gallagher Re.

Most of the homes destroyed in the Eaton and Palisades fires were in three communities: Altadena, a middle-

Please turn to page A8

When You Can't Get Home And Nobody Feels Sorry for You

* * *

Strikes in Venezuela left travelers stranded; 'Boo hoo, you're stuck on an island'

By **MELISSA KORN**
AND **ALLISON POHLE**

SAN JUAN, Puerto Rico—Synda Clements came here to celebrate her 40th birthday and ring in the New Year.

Now, she's just looking for a way home.

Clements, who met in San Juan with friends and family—including two from Ireland and three from Indiana—was supposed to head back to New York on Saturday evening. But that morning, friends scheduled to leave on an earlier flight alerted the group that the airspace above

the Caribbean island was closed after U.S. military action in Venezuela. All flights were being canceled.

To make matters worse, some of her friends back home aren't too sympathetic. She's getting messages along the lines of "Boo hoo, you're stuck on an island," she said.

The strikes in Caracas and arrest of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro have upended the geopolitical order across Latin America. It also created the ultimate first-world problem: tens of thousands of travelers stuck in exotic locations. Please turn to page A8

How UnitedHealth Killing Changed Corporate Security

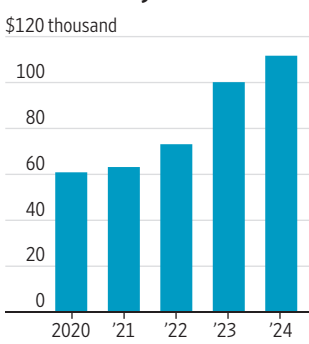
By **CHIP CUTTER**
AND **THEO FRANCIS**

When the CEOs of Delta Air Lines, International Business Machines, Target and others gathered for a confab in New York in December, stepped-up security was apparent before attendees even walked in.

A New York Police Department cruiser sat opposite the main entrance. Officers milled about nearby. Executives received instructions telling them to expect elevated security throughout the day.

The protocols reflect a new reality in corporate security a year after UnitedHealthcare Chief Executive Brian Thompson was killed on a New York City sidewalk nearby. Some of the business world's most visible CEOs, such as Elon Musk,

Median S&P 500 spending on personal security for executives beyond work



Note: Excludes personal travel by corporate aircraft
Source: Equilar

now travel surrounded by a bevy of bodyguards. Even small companies are bulking up their efforts to safeguard top brass. Yet protecting top executives

against security threats remains more challenging than ever, security professionals said.

More boards are insisting on tighter security, pointing to resentment of big business and rising violence—including the killings of conservative activist Charlie Kirk and a Democratic Minnesota legislator and her husband. A shooting in New York's midtown last summer—when a former high-school football player killed four people at a building housing the offices of the National Football League, Blackstone and accounting firm KPMG—has also spurred action.

"The threats are absolutely still there," said Brian Stephens, a former chief security officer at Bank of America who advises companies about

Please turn to page A2

INSIDE



SPORTS
Tom Brady's latest Hail Mary: Saving the Las Vegas Raiders. **A16**

PERSONAL JOURNAL
Trying out an AI fitness coach that doesn't accept excuses. **A9**

Ford Is Struggling to Fill Six-Figure Mechanic Jobs

By **CHRISTOPHER OTTS**

KENT, Ohio—Just after 7 a.m. on a recent morning, Ted Hummel leapt up onto the front bumper of a 2019 Ford F-150 and reached under the hood to disconnect a pair of oxygen-sensor connectors.

It is the first step of dozens to replace the truck's transmission, a job that is expected to take about 10 hours. Hummel is confident he can do it in half the time. "I should have it out of there by lunch," he said.

Most mechanics at the Klaben Ford dealership in Kent, Ohio, hate messing with transmissions, the duffel-bag-shaped, 300-pound machines that transfer power to the vehicle's wheels. Hummel is one of the few who relish diagnosing

their problems, taking them apart and finagling them in and out of trucks.

A soft-spoken, 39-year-old father of two, Hummel is one of Ford Motor's highest-status automotive technicians—a "senior master."

For that, he is rewarded. Hummel said he earned about \$160,000 for 2025. There is almost always a transmission for him to work on, and in the unconventional system for mechanics' pay, Hummel's efficiency means more money for him and for his dealership.

"I wish we could clone Ted," said Sean Bradford, Klaben Ford's service manager and Hummel's boss.

There aren't enough Teds. Not only at Klaben Ford, but Please turn to page A4